

Enemy in the House: A 6-Week Reintroduction Protocol for Sudden Cat Aggression

Introduction: This Isn't Your Fault

You're holding your phone, watching two cats you adopted together snarl and attack each other over a doorway. Three weeks ago, they groomed each other. Now one is living in the bathroom and you don't know how this happened — or if it can be undone.

This is not a behavioral problem you caused by being a bad cat parent. It's called **redirected aggression**, and it is one of the most misunderstood and mishandled feline emergencies in existence. It starts with a trigger — a fight outside the window, a loud noise, a new cat smell on your clothes — and cascades into a real, neurobiological grudge that can last months or, in extreme cases, permanently.

The good news: cats don't hold grudges the way we think. They hold **fear associations**, and fear associations can be systematically broken down. That's exactly what this product does.

By the end of this guide, you will have a day-by-day reintroduction protocol grounded in proven, incremental exposure methods — not vague "keep them separated" advice that leaves you guessing for months. You will know how to identify the trigger, restore safety,

and rebuild your multi-cat household without professional behaviorist fees or surrendering to a shelter.

Part 1: Understanding What Just Happened

The Diagnostic Foundation

The first week of a cat aggression crisis is disorienting. You're in damage-control mode, probably separating cats in ad-hoc ways, and every hissing sound makes you flinch. Before you can fix anything, you need to understand exactly what happened — because redirected aggression follows a specific pattern, and recognizing that pattern is what allows you to reverse it.

This section gives you the diagnostic tools. You'll create a timeline, identify the trigger chain, and calculate each cat's fear threshold. These three pieces of information form the foundation for everything else in the protocol.

Chapter 1: Map Your Cat's Threat History

The first thing you need to do is reconstruct the timeline of what happened. Not guess. Not vaguely remember. Actually reconstruct it, because redirected aggression has a very specific signature, and once you see it, you'll stop second-guessing yourself.

Here's what redirected aggression looks like in motion: A calm cat becomes suddenly reactive to something — a noise outside, a strange cat visible through the window, a sudden change in their environment. That reactive energy has nowhere to go, so it gets redirected onto the nearest available target. Usually another cat. That cat didn't do anything wrong, but now they're associated with the original trigger in the attacking cat's mind. Fear has been transferred. The grudge, if you want to call it that, is born.

Your Action Step: Create the Incident Timeline

Take a blank piece of paper or open a notes app and write down the following:

- 1. The Last Peaceful Memory:** When did you last see your cats grooming each other, eating side by side, or sleeping together without incident? Be specific. Date and time if possible.
- 2. The First Aggression Event:** When did you first notice aggression between the cats? What exactly happened — hissing, chasing, full attack? Was there an external event you noticed around the same time (noise, someone came home, you returned from somewhere)?
- 3. The Cascade:** How did the aggression evolve over the following hours and days? Did one cat start stalking the other? Did the "victim" cat start acting fearful even when the aggressor wasn't present?
- 4. Current State:** Where are the cats now? What does a typical day look like in terms of their locations, their interactions, and their stress signals?

You're looking for a window of time between a trigger event and the first act of aggression. This window is usually minutes to a few hours. If your cats were fine on Tuesday and fighting on Wednesday, something happened on Tuesday evening or Wednesday morning that you might have missed. A car alarm, a delivery person, a neighborhood cat visible through the window, a veterinary visit. Write down every possibility you can think of.

The goal here isn't to assign blame — to yourself, your cat, or circumstance. The goal is to identify the original source of the fear so you can neutralize it from the environment.

Key Takeaway: Redirected aggression has a signature pattern: trigger → reactive cat → redirected attack → fear association. Recreating the timeline helps you identify where the chain started and gives you a starting point for environmental management.

Chapter 2: Identify the Trigger Chain

Now that you have the timeline, it's time to identify the actual trigger. This is where most people get stuck — they know the cats

are fighting, but they don't know why, so they can't remove the source of the problem. That's what the Trigger Inventory is for.

Redirected aggression triggers fall into several categories:

Environmental Triggers

- Cats outside the home visible through windows or doors
- Construction or loud noises (neighbors, HVAC work, thunderstorms)
- New objects in the home that smell unfamiliar (new furniture, carpet, litter mat)
- Strong cleaning product scents or air fresheners
- Moving or rearranging furniture

Olfactory Triggers

- You handling another cat (veterinary office, friend's home, shelter volunteering)
- New cat in the household (even if it's a neighbor's cat you visited)
- Recently changed litter brands or cleaning products
- Cat carriers that weren't stored properly after a veterinary visit

Health-Related Triggers

- One cat recently returned from a veterinary visit (especially if stressed or examined roughly)
- A cat in pain from an injury or illness (which may not be visible to you)
- A cat with an undiagnosed condition causing discomfort (dental disease, arthritis, urinary issues)

Social Disruption Triggers

- New person in the household
- Someone leaving or returning after an absence
- Changes in your own stress or schedule

Your Action Step: Complete the Trigger Inventory Worksheet

For each potential trigger below, rate it on a scale of 1–3: (1 = unlikely, 2 = possible, 3 = highly likely based on your timeline)

POTENTIAL TRIGGER	DID THIS HAPPEN?	RATING (1-3)
Cat visible outside window/door		
Loud noise (construction, thunder, appliance)		
New smell in home (cleaning, furniture, air freshener)		
I handled another cat recently		
Cat returned from veterinary visit		
New person in household		
Litter or feeding change		
Cat showing signs of illness/pain		
Furniture or room rearrangement		
Neighborhood cat conflict		

Add any triggers specific to your situation that aren't listed.

Now, look at your highest-rated items. These are your primary suspects. The goal is to remove or neutralize as many of them as possible before you begin reintroduction. You can't control every sound outside, but you can close blinds when needed, use

pheromone diffusers, and ensure the environment is as stable as possible.

Key Takeaway: Redirected aggression triggers fall into environmental, olfactory, health-related, and social categories. Your Trigger Inventory worksheet identifies the most likely culprits so you can address them proactively.

Chapter 3: Assess Fear Threshold and Safety State

Here's where you get honest about where you actually are in this crisis. I see a lot of people jump straight to reintroduction protocols when they haven't stabilized their cats first — and that almost always makes things worse. Before you can move forward, you need to know the current fear threshold score for each cat.

Fear Threshold Scoring Rubric (1–10)

Use this rubric to score each cat individually:

SCORE	DESCRIPTION	INDICATORS
1-2	Relaxed, comfortable	Slow blinking, relaxed ears, normal posture, eating, grooming normally
3-4	Mildly cautious	Some alertness, occasional hiding, slightly tense body language
5-6	Moderately fearful	Hissing, growling, piloerection (fur standing up), crouching, avoiding
7-8	Highly fearful/aggressive	Swatting through barriers, lunging at barriers, sustained hissing, ears flat
9-10	Crisis mode	Full attack on other cat, self-injury, extreme hiding, refusal to eat

Your Action Step: Score Each Cat and Determine Protocol

1. Observe each cat separately (not interacting with each other) over a 24-hour period
2. Score each cat using the rubric above
3. Determine your household status:

Level 7-10 (Crisis Mode): Full separation required. No visual contact. Begin with complete scent separation (separate blankets, separate rooms, wash hands between handling). Do not attempt any reintroduction activities until both cats score 5 or below consistently for 48 hours.

Level 5-6 (Moderate Crisis): Separation with environmental management. Limited visual contact through a closed door may

begin if both cats are eating well. No direct contact. Focus on scent swapping and positive environmental enrichment.

Level 3–4 (Recovery Phase): You may begin the full reintroduction protocol. Both cats are stressed but not in crisis. Proceed with caution and daily scoring.

Level 1–2 (Minor Incident): If you caught this early and scores are low, you may be able to skip to later phases of reintroduction more quickly — but don't skip scent work entirely.

Write down each cat's score and your current household level. This determines your starting point. If you're in crisis mode, everything in Part 4 gets paused until you're in moderate or recovery phase.

Key Takeaway: Fear threshold scoring tells you where you actually are, not where you wish you were. A crisis-level household (7–10) needs full separation before any reintroduction begins. Be honest with your scoring — optimism won't change a cat's stress chemistry.

Part 2: Stabilizing Your Household

The Safety Infrastructure

You have your diagnosis. You know the trigger, you have the timeline, and you've scored each cat's fear threshold. Now it's time to build the safety infrastructure that will hold everything together for the next six weeks.

This is the unglamorous work. It involves cardboard boxes, strategic litter placement, and learning to read tail positions. But it's infrastructure — and just like you wouldn't try to run a city without roads, you can't successfully reintroduce cats without a stable environment first.

Chapter 4: Creating a Functional Separation Zone

The bathroom is not a long-term solution. I know it's where most people default when aggression strikes — it's enclosed, easy to clean, and contained. But a bathroom lacks vertical space, natural

light, and enrichment opportunities. A cat can survive in a bathroom for days. They cannot thrive there for weeks, and a stressed, under-stimulated cat will not make progress in reintroduction.

Your Separation Zone Requirements

Each cat needs a complete "base camp":

- **A room with vertical space:** A spare bedroom, office, or large bathroom with shelves/cat trees. The cat should be able to get off the floor and feel elevated.
- **All resources within the room:** Litter box (one per cat plus one, but in this case, each separated cat needs at least one), food bowl, water bowl, scratching post, hiding spots.
- **No shared resources through barriers:** Food and water should not be placed directly on opposite sides of a door where cats can sense each other eating.
- **Safe hiding spots:** Cardboard boxes with entry holes, covered beds, or draped blankets over furniture.
- **Window access (if possible):** Visual access to the outside world provides stimulation and can help reduce stress.

Your Action Step: Audit and Upgrade Your Separation Zones

Walk through each separation room and evaluate:

1. Does this cat have vertical space? If not, add a cat tree, shelves, or stacking boxes with blankets.
2. Is the litter box in a good location? Not near food, in a corner where the cat feels trapped, or in a high-traffic area.
3. Does this cat have at least two hiding options?
4. Is there a window or other visual stimulation?
5. Have I washed my hands and changed clothes after handling the aggressor cat before interacting with the victim (and vice versa)?

Make one upgrade today. Tomorrow, make another. You don't have to do this all at once, but the environment should be improving, not stagnating.

Key Takeaway: Separation zones need to be enriching, not just safe. A cat in a barren bathroom for six weeks will decompensate. Give each cat vertical space, hiding spots, and stimulation — even in separation.

Chapter 5: Reading Stress Signals

You can't manage what you can't measure. And you can't measure your cats' stress if you don't know what it looks like.

People tend to think aggression is the only problem signal. But cats show stress in subtle, continuous ways — long before a full attack occurs. Learning to read these signals is what separates successful reintroduction from repeated setbacks.

The Feline Stress Signal Hierarchy

From subtle to obvious:

- 1. Ear rotation:** Ears turned sideways or backward indicate mild alertness or discomfort. Not yet a problem, but worth noting.
- 2. Whale eye:** When you can see the white of a cat's eyes (the sclera), they're showing "whale eye" — a sign of significant anxiety. They're 警觉 and feel exposed.
- 3. Body tension and crouching:** A cat lowering their body, tucking their paws under, or making themselves small is in defensive mode.
- 4. Tail lashing or puffed tail:** A rapidly swishing tail isn't playful in cats — it's agitation. A puffed tail (piloerection) is full fear response.
- 5. Hissing and growling:** These are distance-increasing signals. The cat is saying "go back." Don't ignore them, but don't panic either. This is information.
- 6. Swatting and lunging:** Active defensive or offensive behavior. This is a red zone. Stop whatever is happening immediately.

Your Action Step: Create a Stress Log

For the next three days, spend 10 minutes twice daily observing each cat (separately) and recording:

- Time of observation
- Cat's location and position
- Body language observed (ears, tail, posture)
- Behaviors (eating, grooming, hiding, vocalizing)
- Anything notable that happened before the observation

After three days, you'll have a baseline. You'll start seeing patterns — maybe one cat is more stressed in the morning, maybe the victim cat's stress decreases when you do specific enrichment activities. This log becomes your early warning system.

Key Takeaway: Cats communicate stress continuously through subtle body language. Learning to read whale eye, ear position, and tail movement gives you hours of advance notice before a crisis-level event.

Chapter 6: Building Your Resource Safety Net

Redirected aggression often escalates when cats feel resource competition. Even in separation, resource management matters — because if one cat feels their resources are threatened, they'll enter reintroduction already primed for conflict.

The Five Resources Cats Care About

1. **Food:** Predictable feeding schedule, no competition at mealtimes
2. **Water:** Multiple water sources, cleaned daily
3. **Litter:** Clean, uncovered, in a location that doesn't feel trapped
4. **Resting spots:** Vertical space, sunny spots, cozy hides
5. **Human attention:** Predictable play sessions and social time

Your Action Step: Resource Equity Audit

Walk through your separation setup and ask:

- Does each cat have their own food bowl, water bowl, and litter box?
- Are resources spread throughout the room, not clustered in one corner?

- Is the victim cat's resources in a location where they won't be ambushed if barriers come down?
- Am I giving equal quality time to both cats, or is one getting more attention?

Address any inequities today. This is maintenance-level work, not exciting, but it prevents the underground resentment that derails reintroduction.

Key Takeaway: Resource competition is a silent reintroduction killer. Ensure every cat has their own equipment, placed in locations that feel safe — even in separation.

Part 3: Preparing for Reintroduction

The Foundation Phase

You've stabilized the household. Cats are separated, stress signals are being monitored, and resources are equitable. Now you're ready to start the actual reintroduction process — but not in the way you might think.

Reintroduction doesn't begin with the cats seeing each other. It begins with them smelling each other, hearing each other, and — most importantly — associating each other's presence with good things. This foundation work is what makes visual reintroduction successful. Skip it, and you're starting a marathon on a broken leg.

Chapter 7: Scent and Sensory Preparation

Cats are olfactory creatures. They know the world through smell more than sight. When a cat hisses at another cat after a redirected aggression incident, they're not recognizing a face — they're recognizing a scent profile that has become associated with fear.

Scent swapping isn't woo-woo. It's applied neuroscience. You're replacing a fear-association with a neutral or positive one.

The Scent Swapping Protocol

You'll need:

- Several small cotton socks or washcloths (no strong laundry detergent scent)
- A small ziplock bag for each cat
- A designated trading schedule

Your Action Step: Begin the Scent Swap Ritual

1. Take one sock and rub it gently on Cat A's cheeks, chin, and forehead (where scent glands are concentrated). Do not wash your hands between handling the sock and the cat — this is intentional.
2. Place the sock in a ziplock bag and seal it.
3. Take the sock to the room where Cat B is separated. Let Cat B sniff it freely. Do not force it near their face. Let them approach on their own terms.
4. If Cat B sniffs the sock without hissing, give them a small high-value treat. If they hiss, remove the sock and try again tomorrow.
5. Alternate days: Day 1, swap Cat A's scent to Cat B's room. Day 2, swap Cat B's scent to Cat A's room.
6. After one week, you can leave the sock in the other cat's room between exchanges — just observe initial reactions.

Additional scent work:

- Rotate blankets between rooms so each cat sleeps on the other's scent
- Use a brush on one cat and then immediately brush the other (if they're comfortable with brushing)
- If you have Feliway Classic or Feliway Multicat diffusers, plug them in throughout the home, especially in separation rooms

Key Takeaway: Scent swapping is applied neuroscience. You're not making cats "friends" through smell — you're breaking the

fear-association that their olfactory system has encoded. Let cats approach new scents on their own terms.

Chapter 8: Positive Association Building

Scent swapping is passive — it happens whether you're there or not. Positive association building is active: you're creating direct links between the other cat's presence and good things.

The Feeding-at-Barrier Protocol

This is the cornerstone of positive association. Here's how it works:

1. Place food bowls on opposite sides of the separation barrier (the closed door). Both bowls should be equidistant from the door.
2. Feed both cats simultaneously. They'll hear and smell each other eating, but they won't have visual contact.
3. If either cat stops eating, they've been pushed past their comfort threshold. Move the bowls further from the door.
4. Repeat daily, tracking how close to the door each cat will eat comfortably.

Your Action Step: Start the Feeding-at-Barrier Protocol

1. Place both food bowls three feet from the door on each side.
2. Feed both cats simultaneously.
3. Observe: Does each cat eat normally? Do they pause, look toward the door, or vocalize?
4. If comfortable, repeat tomorrow with the same placement.
5. If comfortable for three consecutive days, move bowls one foot closer.
6. Continue until bowls are one foot from the door — or until you hit a setback (cats refuse to eat, hissing, trying to get through the door).

Setbacks are normal. If they occur, move bowls back to the previous comfortable distance and hold there for a few extra days before trying to advance again.

Additional Positive Association Techniques

- Play sessions near the door (with your back to the door, focused on the cat)
- Treats given near the door while the other cat is on the other side
- Slow-blinking exercises: when a cat shows calm body language near the door, slow-blink at them and give a treat

Key Takeaway: The Feeding-at-Barrier protocol creates positive associations with the other cat's presence. Start far from the door and advance slowly — there are no awards for rushing.

Chapter 9: Your Reintroduction Readiness Checklist

Before you move to Part 4 — the actual visual reintroduction phases — pause and confirm you're ready. This checklist exists so you don't start Phase 1 with unresolved instability and then blame the protocol when it fails.

Reintroduction Readiness Checklist

Complete this before starting Chapter 10:

CRITERION	CAT A STATUS	CAT B STATUS	NOTES
Fear threshold score ≤ 5			
Eating and drinking normally			
Grooming normally			
Not hiding constantly			
Comfortable eating one foot from door			
No whale eye or sustained hissing near door			
Separation room is enriching (vertical space, hiding spots, window access)			
Resource equity established			
Scent swap tolerated (no extreme reactions)			
I'm not exhausted and resentful			

If any of the cat-specific criteria aren't met, you need more time in Part 2 stabilization. If the last criterion — "I'm not exhausted and resentful" — is a no, that's also data. Reintroduction requires patience and consistency. If you're running on fumes, you will not execute the protocol well.

Your Action Step: Complete the Checklist and Make One Adjustment

Go through the checklist honestly. For every item that's not fully met, write down one specific action you'll take in the next 24 hours to address it. Then, when you start Part 4, you'll have the foundation you actually need — not the foundation you wish you had.

Key Takeaway: The readiness checklist is your gatekeeper. Rushing into visual reintroduction with unresolved instability almost always causes setbacks. Take the checklist seriously.

Part 4: The 6-Week Reintroduction Protocol

From Separation to Coexistence

This is the protocol. Day-by-day, phase-by-phase, with specific benchmarks for advancement and specific failure modes to watch for. The timeline is six weeks — faster if things go well, slower if setbacks occur. Your cats don't read calendars. They respond to readiness signals, and the protocol is designed to follow those signals.

Chapter 10: Phase 1 — Separated Scent Exchange and Sensory Re-Introduction (Weeks 1–2)

Week 1 Targets

By the end of Week 1, you should see:

- Both cats comfortable with scent swaps (no extreme reactions)
- Both cats eating within one foot of the separation door
- Fear threshold scores at 4 or below for both cats
- Stress signals declining (less whale eye, less constant hiding)

Week 1 Daily Protocol

DAY	MORNING	EVENING
1-2	Scent swap (Cat A to Cat B's room)	Feeding at barrier (bowls 3 ft from door)
3-4	Scent swap (Cat B to Cat A's room)	Feeding at barrier (bowls 3 ft from door)
5	Rotate blankets between rooms	Feeding at barrier (advance if comfortable)
6-7	Scent swap (alternate)	Feeding at barrier (advance if comfortable)

Week 2 Targets

By the end of Week 2, you should see:

- Both cats comfortable with blankets swapped from the other cat's room
- Both cats eating right next to the door (within one foot)
- Play sessions possible near the door on both sides
- Occasional slow blinking visible when cats are near the door

Week 2 Advancement Criteria

Before advancing to Phase 2, both cats must demonstrate:

1. No hissing when smelling the other cat's scent (mild wariness is okay; active aversion is not)
2. Normal eating and grooming within one foot of the door
3. Relaxed body language (soft eyes, neutral ears) when near the door
4. At least one instance of calm behavior visible from both sides

Your Action Step: Document Progress with a Simple Log

Keep a one-line log each day:

- Day 1: Cat A ate 3ft from door, sniffed Cat B's sock, no reaction.
Cat B ate 2ft from door, hissed once at sock.

This doesn't need to be elaborate. It helps you see patterns over time and recognize when you're advancing too fast.

What Failure Looks Like

If at any point during Phase 1 you observe:

- Sustained hissing or growling from both cats near the door
- Refusal to eat near the door for more than three consecutive days
- One or both cats showing fear threshold scores of 7 or above
- Cats attempting to attack through the door

...then you're not in Phase 1 readiness. Return to Part 2 stabilization. Do not advance. The protocol requires readiness signals — not wishful thinking.

Key Takeaway: Phase 1 is pure sensory work: smell, sound, and proximity associations. If you rush this phase to get to "the real reintroduction," you'll spend longer fixing the setback than you saved.

Chapter 11: Phase 2 — Controlled Visual Contact with Resource Management (Weeks 3–4)

Now you're ready for the cats to see each other. But not fully. Phase 2 uses a barrier — a baby gate covered with a screen, or a 宠物栅栏 with visual access — to allow controlled, supervised visual contact.

Your Barrier Setup

- **Baby gate with screen:** Install a standard baby gate in a doorway, then cover it with mesh/screen fabric (available at hardware stores). This allows visual contact while preventing physical access.
- **Height matters:** If one cat is significantly more aggressive, position the barrier so the less-aggressive cat has access to higher ground on their side.

- **Escape routes:** Each cat must have a path to retreat. Don't set up the barrier in a corner where one cat feels trapped.

The Treat Chain Method

This is your primary tool for Phase 2:

1. Both cats are on opposite sides of the barrier, fed simultaneously.
2. You hold a high-value treat near your hand and slowly move your hand toward the barrier, giving treats to each cat as they look toward the other side.
3. The goal: each cat associates the other cat's visual presence with treats coming from your hand.
4. Keep sessions short (3–5 minutes) and end on a positive note.
5. Track approach distance: how close can you hold treats to the barrier before a cat disengages?

Week 3 Protocol

- Days 1–3: Feeding sessions through barrier with treats. Bowls placed 3 feet from barrier.
- Days 4–5: Bowls moved to 2 feet from barrier. Continue treat chain.
- Days 6–7: Bowls at 1 foot from barrier. Observe body language throughout.

Week 3 Advancement Criteria

- Both cats eating within one foot of barrier
- No sustained staring contests (brief glances are fine)
- At least one slow blink visible from each cat toward the other side
- Either cat voluntarily approaching the barrier

Week 4 Protocol

- Days 1–3: Bowls right next to barrier. Treat chain continues.
- Days 4–5: Play sessions with interactive wands while both cats are in view. You're the distraction.
- Days 6–7: Treat sessions with bowls removed — only visual presence and treats, no food bowls.

Week 4 Advancement Criteria

- Both cats showing positive body language near barrier (slow blinks, relaxed ears, forward-facing posture)
- Either cat voluntarily walking up to the barrier
- No piloerection, no growling, no lunging
- Both cats comfortable with short periods (3–5 minutes) of visual contact without food bowls present

What Failure Looks Like

Setbacks in Phase 2 look like:

- Piloerection (fur standing up) when visual contact occurs
- Sustained staring without blinking
- Lunge attempts toward the barrier
- One cat refusing to enter the room where the barrier is set up
- Reappearance of fear threshold scores above 5

If setbacks occur, return bowls to the previous comfortable distance. Add more sessions at that distance before attempting advancement again.

Key Takeaway: The treat chain method creates positive associations with visual contact. You're not teaching cats to tolerate each other — you're teaching them that seeing each other predicts good things.

Chapter 12: Phase 3 — Unsupervised Reintroduction and Troubleshooting Regression (Weeks 5–6)

Phase 3 is unsupervised access. For short periods, the barrier comes down and you allow full access — but you're there to supervise, and you have an exit strategy.

The Step Stool Method

This is how you reintroduction full access:

1. Remove the barrier. Both cats are now in the same space with you present.

2. Have two step stools (or small tables) available — these are your "safety stations." When you see tension rising, you can place a stool between the cats or toss treats to create distance.
3. Keep sessions short: 5–10 minutes initially.
4. End every session before it goes bad. If you wait until a fight starts to end the session, you've taught both cats that this is how encounters end.

Week 5 Protocol

- Days 1–2: Supervised access, 5 minutes, one room only. Keep yourself busy (reading, working on laptop) so you're present but not hovering.
- Days 3–4: Supervised access, 10 minutes. Continue step stool method.
- Days 5–7: Supervised access, 15 minutes. One cat may start following the other; observe body language.

Week 5 Benchmark

By end of Week 5, you should see:

- Both cats in the same room without active aggression
- Mutual tolerance (not friendship — just absence of attack)
- Cats engaging in normal behaviors (grooming, eating, resting) in shared space
- At least one positive interaction: sniffing followed by walking away calmly, or slow blinking at each other

Week 6 Protocol

- Days 1–2: Supervised access, 20 minutes.
- Days 3–4: Supervised access, 30 minutes. Begin leaving the room briefly (30 seconds to one minute).
- Days 5–6: Unsupervised access in one room while you're in another. Keep sessions to 1 hour initially.
- Day 7: Overnight unsupervised access (optional — only if Week 6 Days 1–6 went smoothly).

Regression Troubleshooting

Regression is normal. It doesn't mean you've failed. It means something shifted — and usually you can identify what.

Common Regression Triggers:

- Environmental change (new furniture, moved litter box, loud event)
- Illness in one cat (pain makes cats irritable)
- Competition over a resource (one cat guarded the food bowl)
- Lack of structure (you got busy and missed play sessions)
- Moving too fast (you advanced phases before cats were ready)

Regression Response Protocol:

1. Return to the previous week's protocol immediately.
2. Identify the likely trigger: Did anything change? Did you miss something?
3. Add extra scent swapping and treat chain sessions for 3–5 days.
4. Only re-advance when both cats are back to the comfort level you saw before regression.

Your Action Step: Know Your Exit Strategy Before You Remove the Barrier

Before Phase 3 Day 1, prepare:

- A carrier open and accessible for each cat (can of tuna or spray bottle nearby if you need to redirect quickly)
- A thick blanket you can throw over an escalating encounter (buys you seconds)
- A step stool or small table to place between cats
- A plan for which cat goes where if things go badly (can you isolate one cat quickly?)

Knowing you have an exit